In

a remote corner of Assam, where the rustle of areca nut (*tamul* in Assamese) leaves falling to the ground went mostly unnoticed, Arindam Dasgupta spied something different. Where others saw waste, he saw possibility. That vision gave birth to Tamul Plates Marketing Pvt Ltd in 2010, a social enterprise founded not in the boardrooms of big cities but in the heart of rural India, with a simple idea and three friends who chose purpose over predictability.

Arindam's journey took him from Jamshedpur to Delhi and then to the Institute of Rural Management, Anand, Gujarat, where a stark paradox struck him. Western India, with its arid terrain and limited natural resources, seemed more prosperous than the resource-rich East. The discrepancy gnawed at him, and, determined to make a change where it was most needed, he moved to Guwahati where he worked as an officer with the Entrepreneurship Development Institute of India. In 2005, along with a few like-minded friends, Arindam launched Vrithi, a non-profit with the aim of generating sustainable livelihoods in rural communities. But it was only after they noticed the abundance of fallen *tamul* leaves, and no means to use them, that they found their eureka moment.

Areca leaf plates were already popular in south India, celebrated for their biodegradability and strength. In Assam, however, despite the abundance of the raw material, there was no ecosystem to process it. Arindam and his team decided to bridge that gap with Tamul Plates, marrying environmental responsibility with rural entrepreneurship. "A resource like areca leaves was just falling to the ground," says Arindam. "If we value-add locally, we can create jobs, reduce plastic use, and protect the planet."

Blending local resource use, decentralised production and community ownership, the enterprise's operations run on two complementary models: a centralised 2,000 sq. m. factory in Tihu that manufactures lakhs of plates each month, and a cluster model where over 1,500 rural women operate machines from their homes across districts like Baksa, Kamrup, Golaghat, Tamulpur, and parts of Meghalaya. "We provide complete handholding, training, technology and marketing support, so that these women can earn Rs 10,000-15,000 a month," says Debaleena Ray, chief impact officer of Tamul Plates. The model now spans over 500 villages, supports 6,000 livelihoods and includes more than 20 tribal communities. Women make up 60 per cent of the employees and 80 per cent of the raw material collectors, while even differently abled individuals play vital roles across the supply chain. What began in a bamboo shed has grown into a company producing 1 million plates a month, clocking Rs 3 crore in revenue for FY25.

Tamul's model is deceptively simple yet profoundly impactful. Areca nut leaves, often discarded and left to rot, are collected, cleaned and pressed into sturdy, elegant plates using just heat and water, sans chemicals, or fuss. These plates decompose in 60-90 days, offering a clean, natural alternative to plastic and polystyrene. The enterprise has also begun exporting to countries as far-flung as Australia, France, Colombia, England, the United States and Sri Lanka. Their prices, once double those of plastic, are now only marginally higher. "Now, we're just 20–30 per cent more expensive and infinitely better for the planet," says co-founder Manabendra Pathak.

Tamul Plates is rewriting the story of rural enterprise, generating wealth from waste. All it needed was for someone to pick up a fallen, forgotten leaf and turn it into a brilliant idea. ■

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Tamul Plates

What they do: **Make dinnerware out of areca nut leaf waste**

Founded in: **2010**

Co-owner: **Manabendra Pathak, 47**

Annual turnover
Rs 3 crore

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